More than serving as a "secretariat office", the exchange of resources among distinctive members explains the pervasive informal institutional power of the MPC. However, it is a matter of dispute whether the growing informal power of the MPC was a good or bad thing. The tight networks with self-contained agenda often provoked other stakeholders' discontent. Those disappointed included some working committee members who felt excluded from membership, especially the members of parliament, some associated departments from the administration, and the non-state owned media (interviews with three parliamentarians, 2014; with members of UPWC, 2014; and with a senior executive from the Ministry of National Planning, 2015). The MPC's practices during the peace process were often criticized for their exclusionary nature. Some critics from the local media and lawmakers were attentive to its "out-of-the-public-eye gatherings" with some ethnic leaders, including some leaders from the KNU, and spending donor money on individual institutional projects in the hope of redirecting policy attention towards the implementation of a narrowly focused private agenda.[6]

Shared goals and coordination with key stakeholders

Individuals within the MPC under the Thein Sein government shared explicit and implicit goals. Key members integrated as a tight and small group at the centre of the peace policy community in order to address officially declared objectives: (i) ceasefire negotiations; and (ii) political dialogue with the EAGs (interviews with the members of the UPWC and the MPC, 2015). Cognizant of the ups and downs in the peace process in recent years, the MPC members were aware that to have all EAGs sign the NCA would take time. The key members of the MPC were concerned that the process would collapse before the end of the Thein Sein administration. Therefore, the sustainability of the peace process toward the next administration from early on was a pragmatic objective of the MPC (interviews with senior members of the MPC, 2015).

To sustain the peace process, it was vital for the MPC to coordinate effectively and efficiently with key stakeholders, while dealing with constraints. It had to make sure key policy actors would stick to the peace project without giving up. The MPC itself was a brainchild of the Thein Sein government, the major stakeholder in the peace process and also the